

Vikram Kher and Yogesh Nambiar share what Harman's road ahead looks like

"... we are focused on consumers' experience & satisfaction"

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JBL has been one of the most popular brands in the Indian audio markets for years. Known for its signature 'Pure Bass' sound, the brand has launched several products in the Indian market over the years and enjoyed its share of success.

However, despite all that, some questions remain in the mind of the consumers about the brand's strategy going forward and in the current market scenario too. Questions like JBL's strategy to stand against competing Indian brands and what is the reason behind a product getting a Dolby certification? To get answers to all these questions and more, we sat down with Mr Vikram Kher, Vice President, Lifestyle at Harman India and Yogesh Nambiar, Head of Marketing at Harman India. Here are the excerpts from that conversation.

Q How does Harman plan to compete against home-grown brands like boAt, Noise, Boult, and FireBoltt?

Vikram: Okay. So let me answer it in this way. Harman welcomes the competition. I firmly believe, rather we firmly believe that competition is always good. Not only for consumers but also for market leaders like Harman or different industries having different brands. So without taking the names of any brand, I believe that we can stand our ground. Our focus is primarily

on what consumers want. And with our 75 years of expertise in research and development to create what we call JBL Signature Sound in marketing language.

For that, consumers are willing to move from Flip 4 to Flip 5, to Flip 6, to whatever in future will be coming, we will be offering the best quality product, which is good for the consumers. And that is one short way, which is to summarize understanding customers' needs and providing the right quality, which is required, which will add value to his environment or his life. That is the only way any brand can compete with the competition. So without worrying about competition, we are focused on consumers' experience and customer satisfaction.

Q We recently reviewed a pair of JBL earphones, and its "Pure Bass" sound signature affected the listening experience in terms of clarity of vocals. Any comments?

Vikram: So the bass is one subject where sometimes

the consumer is not fully aware on what are the pros and cons. If you ask a layman consumer, they feel that bass is the best sound for us, which is not right. So, what we are doing in our recent launches is app support. If you use JBL's app, you can have the flexibility to tweak the bass as per your own taste. And this taste will keep on changing probably, in India, our experiences, everybody wants high bass. Right? Which is not good for your ears. So we want to give

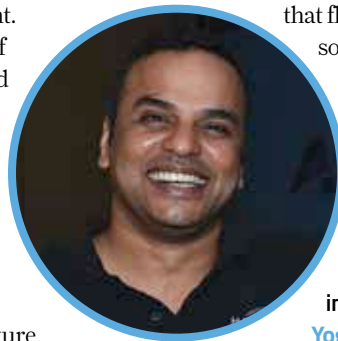
that flexibility to the consumer so that they can tweak the bass based on their taste and requirements.

Q JBL is a subsidiary of Harman. But, we do not see Harman's balanced sound signature in JBL products. Why?

Yogesh: So I'll take that question. So Harman has its signature code, and so does JBL. Okay. Harman addresses a certain customer segment, and JBL

addresses a separate audience profile of consumers. JBL has a separate following, okay? People who are listening to JBL it need to have a JBL Signature Sound. And when you're listening to Harman, it needs to have a Harman sound that comes attached to it. So, which is where they both don't go together. Our engineers are separate for Harman Kardon versus JBL. They both sit separately. Designs are separate. That is because the consumer profile is totally different. When Sidney Harman and Bernard Kardon designed Harman Kardon, they weren't thinking about what James Bullough Lansing was designing on JBL, right? So when we got JBL under our wing, we obviously didn't want to tinker with what James planned for. They both have their separate signatures, and we've kept that legacy.

Vikram: And believe me, there is a huge fan following for the JBL Signature Sound as well. In fact, Yogi (Yogesh), when he designs his marketing collaterals and the campaigns, we make it a point to talk about JBL's Signature Sound. Our consumer segments are different. The consumer profiles that we target are different for Harman and JBL. **Q**



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